of European truth and discernment begins to shed its beams upon the obscurity of the past'.[42] The emerging Hindu nationalists were only too happy to accept the British view of Muslims. Consequently, in most 'British colonial and Hindu nationalist histories', writes Fogelin, 'the Muslim invaders are credited with destroying Buddhism—with [Khilji's] act serving as an example of Muslim depravity'.[43] B.R. Ambedkar, who became a Buddhist months before his death, also blamed the fall of Buddhism (and Nalanda in particular) on Muslim invasions and Islam.[44] As Omvedt noted, 'Ambedkar as well as distinguished historians like [AL] Basham fell into a Hindutva conceptual trap in blaming Islam.'[45] Contemporary prejudices and stereotypes about Buddhism and Islam—one now 'synonymous with peace, tranquility, and introspection, the other with violence, chaos, and blind faith'[46]—further complicate historical revisions.

A naïve visitor might think that the psychic shock of Nalanda's plunder was so great that it lives on in local cultural memory. But even if Khilji had plundered Nalanda himself, it is highly unlikely that any memory of it would have survived in modern Bihar. Buddhism was entirely ousted in Bihar and the rest of India, its monuments physically buried, and the Buddha's historicity forgotten (except in the western Himalayan regions close to Tibet, in Ladakh, Lahaul and Spiti). Buddhism prospered outside India, writes scholar Jawhar Sircar, 'but in its cradle and nursery its existence was snuffed out: not only physically but in terms of history, education and popular memory'.[47] Generations of villagers, at times raiding Nalanda's exposed red bricks, had no idea what the ruins represented. Rather, what animates the melancholy lamentations of the 'official guides' and others today is a case of what Thapar has called 'the construction of social memory', led by the sectarian eye and agendas of twentieth-century Hindu nationalism.[48]

A Modern Revival?

An ambitious new project is underway for an international university at Rajgir, about 15 km from Nalanda. A consortium led by Singapore, Japan,